

THE CATCH

OFFICIAL RULEBOOK — HOW TO PLAY

PLAYERS

1 – 6

ROUNDS

7 per game

TIME

10 – 30 min

PLATFORM

Web / Mobile

MODE

Solo + Online

The Catch is a dating sim with real consequences. Every profile has visible green flags and hidden red ones. Your job is to decide who to date, who to ghost, and who to trust — before the hidden traits are revealed. Same rules. Louder consequences.

♥ DATE

👁️ GHOST

🔍 STALK

⚡ STEAL

♥♥ DOUBLE DATE

🚗 THERAPY

SECTION 01

SETUP & HOW TO START

1 Open the Game

Visit bymayawalsh.design, tap the **The Catch** card, then press ► **PLAY THE GAME**. Runs entirely in-browser — no app, no login required.

2 Choose a Mode

PLAY SOLO — you vs. AI opponents on one device. **PLAY ONLINE** — everyone joins from their own phone using a 4-letter room code (like Jackbox). Host creates the room, others join.

3 Enter Your Name

Pick a name and an avatar emoji. Your name appears on the leaderboard and in score callouts. In online mode, everyone sets this up on their own device before the host starts.

4 Pick a Player Type

Each type changes how trait values score for you. Same profile, completely different results. Locked in for the whole game.

💖 **The Romantic** — positives +1

🎯 **The Selective** — negatives -1 more

🔥 **The Chaotic One** — negatives +2

🌀 **The Overthinker** — -1 traits → -3

📖 **The Avoidant** — extremes drop -1

💰 **The Gold Digger** — strong positives +1

5 Add Custom Traits or People (Optional)

Before starting, add real-life traits you've seen (toggle green or red) or build a full custom person with a name and their actual traits. Both get mixed into the profiles everyone will date.

6 Press START

The game generates 7 unique profiles — including a randomly placed **Catfish**. No two games play the same. Every round a new profile is revealed and the decision phase begins.

SECTION 02

HOW A ROUND WORKS

Each round introduces one profile. You see some traits immediately — others are hidden. You decide whether to date them before the full picture is revealed. 7 rounds, then a final boss.

1 Read the Profile

Each profile shows their name and **2 visible traits** — usually the more moderate flags. Four additional traits are hidden behind question marks and revealed after everyone decides.

2 Choose Your Action

Before the hidden traits are revealed, every player locks in one of the following actions. In online multiplayer, everyone decides simultaneously on their own device.



DATE

CORE

Score all of the profile's traits. Positive total = points. Negative total = lose a heart. Your player type adjusts all values.



GHOST

CORE

Skip the round. No points gained or lost. You have 3 ghosts per game — once gone, you must date or use another action.



STALK

INTEL

Reveal one hidden trait before deciding. Costs one stalk token (3 per game). Then choose DATE or GHOST with better info.



STEAL

ONLINE

Take 3 points from the current score leader. One use per game. If you're the leader, steal from second place.



DOUBLE DATE

ONLINE

Both players date together and split the score. Lower risk, lower reward. Only activates if 2+ players both choose it.



THERAPY

RECOVERY

Auto-skips your next round, then rolls 50/50 for +4 or +0. One use per player. Best used after a string of bad dates.

SECTION 03

SCORING & TRAIT SYSTEM

3 Traits Reveal One by One

After everyone locks in their decision, all hidden traits reveal automatically — one per second. Each trait flashes its value as it appears.

TRAIT VALUE SCALE

FLAG TYPE	BASE VALUE	COLOR
Green Flag — positive traits, good vibes	+1 to +3	● Mint
Yellow Flag — neutral, mildly concerning	0 to -1	● Gold
Red Flag — negative traits, actual problems	-2 to -3	● Neon Red

4 Your Player Type Adjusts Every Score

All trait values are modified by your player type before totaling. The Romantic adds +1 to every positive. The Selective deducts 1 from every negative. Same profile, completely different results — this is the whole game.

5 Score Is Announced

After all traits reveal, a score popup shows your round result. Positive scores glow mint, negative glow red. Your running total updates on the leaderboard.

6 Hearts Track Your Risky Dates

Start with 3 hearts. Every time you DATE and your round total is negative, you lose one heart. Losing all 3 doesn't eliminate you — but makes you ineligible for The One. Hearts are only lost on a negative DATE, never for ghosting, stalking, stealing, or therapy.

🔮 THE CATFISH — SPECIAL RULE

One profile every game is a Catfish. Visible traits look perfect, but all hidden traits are -3. DATE them: take a -4 penalty on top. GHOST them: earn +1 and "Catfish Dodger." No label tells you who it is — trust your gut.

SECTION 04

THE ONE & ENDGAME

💖 WHAT IS "THE ONE"?

After 7 rounds, players with ≥ 10 points *and* at least 1 heart face a final legendary profile — **The One**. Their one hidden trait is worth +5 and can flip the entire leaderboard. If you score negative, you lose your final heart and the points.

7

Face The One (if qualified)

10+ points and 1+ heart → you enter The One screen. One choice: **DATE** (risk it for +5) or **GHOST** (safe exit, no change). Score negative and you lose your last heart plus the points.

8

Tiebreaker (if needed)

If two or more players end with the same score, a Tiebreaker activates — one final profile, all tied players decide simultaneously. Fastest to resolve wins.

9

Results & Achievements

Final leaderboard shows all players ranked by points. Achievements earned appear as emoji badges below each score — the story of how you played, not just the number.

QUICK REFERENCE — ENDGAME QUALIFICATION

THE ONE REQUIREMENTS

Score threshold	≥ 10 points after 7 rounds
Hearts remaining	At least 1 heart (not fully broken)
The One bonus	Hidden trait worth +5
If you fail both	Skip directly to Results

WINNING

Highest score wins	After all rounds including The One and Tiebreaker
Tie resolution	Tiebreaker speed round
Bragging rights	Achievements count as a second score layer

SECTION 05

ACHIEVEMENTS

11 achievements track the story of your run — not just your score. They toast on screen when earned and appear on the final Results page.

**CATFISH DODGER**

Ghosted the catfish. You felt something was off — and you were right.

**GOT CATFISHED**

Dated the catfish. They were too perfect. Should have trusted your gut.

**GHOST MASTER**

Used all three ghosts in a single game. No mess, no drama.

**CHAOS ENJOYER**

Dated every red flag and came back for more.

**RED FLAG RADAR**

Spotted the pattern before it spotted you.

**THERAPIZED**

Used the therapy action. You took a step back — and it paid off.

**SMOOTH CRIMINAL**

Successfully stole points from the leader. They didn't see it coming.

**DOUBLE DATER**

Both you and another player chose Double Date on the same round.

**FOUND THE ONE**

Dated The One and scored positive. Against all odds — you won.

**UNMATCHED**

Dated The One and scored negative. So close — and then it was gone.

**NO SURVIVORS**

Every single date was a red flag. You survived anyway.

QUICK REFERENCE

LIMITS PER GAME

Ghosts	3 per player
Stalk tokens	3 per player
Steal	1 use per player
Therapy	1 use per player
Hearts	3 per player
Catfish	1 per game (rounds 1–5)

MULTIPLAYER TIMER

Time to decide	30 seconds per player
If timer runs out	Auto-ghost (uses one ghost)
Timer bar color	Mint → Gold → Red (urgency)
Steal / Double Date	Multiplayer only (2+ players)

SECTION 06

STRATEGY & TIPS

**Save ghosts for the worst profiles**

You only get 3. Don't waste them early on profiles that might be fine — ghost the ones where the visible traits are already suspicious and you have no stalk tokens left.

**Stalk before committing to a date**

Revealing even one hidden trait can change the math dramatically. If the visible traits look middling, spend a stalk token before deciding. +3 and -3 traits feel completely different when revealed.

**Catfish detection**

The Catfish always looks perfect on the surface. If every visible trait is a green flag with no yellows or reds, that's suspicious. Stalk one hidden trait — if it's deeply negative, ghost immediately.

**Use Steal at the right moment**

Stealing 3 points is most effective in round 5 or 6. Too early and the leader changes. Too late and the gap may be too large. Use it when you're within striking distance.

**Therapy is an investment**

The 50/50 on +4 or +0 is only worth it when you need points and can afford to skip a round. Don't use it round 1 — use it after brutal red flag dates in rounds 4–6.

**Protect your hearts for The One**

Hearts are your ticket to the final round. If you're above 10 points but lost all 3 hearts, you can't face The One. Ghost aggressively in the final 2 rounds if you're sitting on 1 heart.

**Coordinate Double Dates**

Double Date only works if 2+ players choose it simultaneously — without communicating. If you suspect someone will date the same profile, choosing Double Date cuts your risk. If they ghost, you date normally.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Every profile has 6 traits. You only see 2 before deciding. Everything else is a bet. The game isn't about being right — it's about making better bets than everyone else.